

Emigrant Letter – Part 2

Translated into modern and readable English

Date: May 1, 1890

Location: Chicago, USA

Sender: D. (to his parents)

Dear Parents,

My last letter to you was from Liverpool, but now I am writing from Chicago, where we arrived last night at one o'clock. I simply did not have the time to write while in New York. I hope that through the Cunard Line agent in Gothenburg you received word that our ship arrived safely in New York. Since I forgot to mention a great many things about the earlier part of the journey when I wrote from Liverpool, I would like to backtrack a bit in time.

The day before we left Gothenburg, we ran around to all sorts of agents to find the line and vessel that would suit us best, and we finally decided on the Cunard Line. To keep our hands as free as possible upon arrival in New York, and to avoid the risk of being herded back and forth like cattle or ending up at some terrible emigrant hotel, we purchased tickets only as far as New York. They cost 80 kronor per person in third class. We were advised in Gothenburg to buy an upgrade to second class for the journey between Gothenburg and Hull, but we ignored that because we had decided from the start to face the hardships of the journey head-on. At the emigrant office, we bought mattresses for 1.25 kronor each, mess kits for 75 öre, and a knife, fork, and rope to bind our trunks. However, when we boarded at the last minute, it turned out we had only received a mess kit for one of us; the others were nowhere to be found. They were presumably taken by someone else, or the agent had forgotten to pack them.

Later, we deeply regretted buying mattresses in Gothenburg instead of simply bringing an extra blanket each. The mattresses caused us a great deal of trouble and annoyance and were of very little use. First of all, they ruined our clothes terribly when we were forced to lie on them or carry them around, and in the end, they were taken away from us anyway when we boarded the large Atlantic steamship. We did not particularly mourn their loss, but we were annoyed by all the trouble they had caused us. We had far too many pieces of luggage to keep track of, and their number and weight forced out many drops of sweat, as we often had to carry them long distances, heavily dressed as we were.

I have already written about the journey across the North Sea. Hull was a very unpleasant, coal-smoky city. However, the contrast regarding neatness, order, and cleanliness was immense between the English countryside and the city. It was the first thing that caught our eye when we boarded the train to Liverpool immediately after arriving in Hull. The entire countryside looked like a beautiful garden. It felt perhaps a bit too rigid with its perfectly straight paths, rows of trees, and hedges, but it was highly impressive nonetheless. One thing that astonished me greatly was the total lack of telephones; it seems that in England, telephones are viewed as superfluous luxury items. Fortunately, we only had to stay in Liverpool for a single day, whereas many others had been waiting there for an entire week for a ship. About 400–500 Scandinavians were gathered at the emigrant hotel in Liverpool. All of their lighter luggage, except for what they absolutely did not want to risk breaking and therefore carried themselves, was loaded at four o'clock in the morning on April 18 onto two enormous wagons drawn by two gigantic horses. The entire crowd of emigrants then set out on foot for the two-mile walk to the harbor.

Upon reaching the harbor, we boarded a smaller paddle steamer that was to take us out to the Atlantic liner anchored in the river. Before we got on board, however, we had quite a strenuous but memorable time carrying our heavy luggage from the baggage wagons through a long, steeply sloping tunnel down to the quay in a massive crowd. You can imagine the "pleasure" we had with our dusty, lint-covered mattresses in that crush! We brushed and brushed, but we were always just as dusty. Furthermore, it was very difficult to get both washing water and dishwater on board both the North Sea boat and the Atlantic ship. No matter how often we tried to wash, we always felt dirty due to all the grease and soot on board. But so far, we have tried to take everything from its humorous side—cursing one moment and laughing out loud the next.

When the paddle steamer came alongside the large Atlantic vessel, the S/S Aurania, we once again had to hoist all our coats, overnight bags, baskets, bundles of food, hatboxes, blankets, and—of course—those mattresses onto our backs. Since we could not carry everything at once down the steep stairs to the ship's lower decks, we had to leave some items on deck and make two trips. It was during this time that our mattresses, along with the tin mess kits tied to them, disappeared. The mattresses and kits looked identical for everyone, so it was completely impossible to find them again after the ropes had been cut. We were not the only ones who lost their mattresses, and we did not miss them particularly much, but losing the mess kits was worse. Now we had to borrow from others or eat off paper instead of plates.

On the Aurania, all the men were gathered forward, while the unmarried women and families were placed aft. In each cabin, there were four rows of bunks, two upper and two lower, with a narrow aisle down the middle. Each row had six sleeping spaces, meaning there was room for 24 people in each cabin. However, there were only 22 in ours, but it was incredibly cramped nonetheless. I will not say much about the food; it was partly quite good, and we supplemented the rest with our own packed provisions. It was only the manner of eating that was less than pleasant, due to a great lack of proper utensils and dishwater.

The first day we had a very pleasant voyage across the Irish Sea and arrived during the night of Sunday, April 20, at Queenstown, Ireland. There, the ship anchored to take on new passengers and fresh drinking water. The town was beautifully situated on a sloping shore inside a bay. This part of the island certainly seemed to justify the name "the Green Isle" with its bright greenery, though there seemed to be a lack of trees and shaded places. Unfortunately, we were not allowed to go ashore and had to settle for watching from the ship. In Queenstown, the number of emigrants increased by about 400–500 Irishmen, bringing the total number of passengers (including first and second class) to 1,100 people, in addition to a crew of 300—making a total of 1,400 people on board. While we lay at anchor, a lively trade took place along the sides of the ship with oranges for 8 öre each, lemons, tobacco, and clothing. At the same time, two ships from other lines were there for the same purpose and departed at the same time as we did. One ship had more horsepower than ours but a blunter bow, so it did not arrive in New York before us; the third ship arrived much later.

The very day after we left Ireland, we encountered a fierce headwind that intensified the further we went. One night we hit a full storm, and nearly all the emigrants became seasick. They screamed and wailed so much that it was truly miserable to hear. It was not particularly pleasant to lie in the cabin, feeling the violent rolling and seeing all the misery around you. It was the same up on deck during the day. But imagine—neither I nor Arvid felt the slightest bit of seasickness this time either! I believe only about 10 to 15 people out of the 1,100 passengers escaped it entirely, and we even saw many of the sailors get sick. The ship's pitching, when the bow dove deep down and the stern lifted so that the propeller spun in the empty air, was terribly unpleasant, especially when one had to be below deck at night. Even though the ship was so large, the waves crashed over the 40-foot-high bow, pouring across the deck and down through the hatches. The weather was extremely unstable throughout the voyage, and when we passed the Newfoundland Banks, we encountered

icebergs in the Gulf Stream. At night, we were sometimes forced to go at half speed or stop completely. Furthermore, the air was so cold that we froze terribly in our berths, as the hatches to the upper deck were mostly kept open for the sake of ventilation.

The most unpleasant part of the voyage was the poor Irish emigrants we were forced to crowd with on deck. They are described as dirty and rowdy, spreading out everywhere right in the middle of the filth. The contrast with our Swedish girls was enormous; the Swedish girls were clean, neat, healthy, and strong, while the poor Irishwomen were often dirty and unkempt with red or black stringy hair. However, as they neared New York, they "changed skins"—right in the midst of all the emigrants, they brought out their finest clothes and dressed up elegantly.

When we were about a day's journey from New York, we ran into a thick fog that lasted for over 24 hours. It was impossible to see more than 30 fathoms ahead. The steamer was forced to blow its horn around the clock at intervals of just two minutes, and the closer we got to the entrance of New York, the slower we went to avoid collisions. In addition, the ship cast powerful electric searchlights that illuminated everything as if it were the middle of broad daylight. Because of the fog, we could not find the pilot boat that was out to meet us, so we had to glide forward extremely slowly for two days. The last night before we anchored in New York, we witnessed a fantastic spectacle when a violent thunderstorm broke out with sharp lightning and enormous thunderclaps. Due to the dense fog, the ship's lights illuminated the mist while the lightning flashed from the sky, leaving us completely blinded before everything went pitch black again. At the same time, it poured with rain. The thunderstorm lasted for about two hours before the fog finally began to lift. We went to bed at one o'clock in the morning, and on the morning of April 28, we finally anchored in New York. Due to the severe weather, the journey took nine days instead of the normal seven, even though we traveled on one of the fastest ocean liners. One evening during the voyage, a concert was organized in the first-class saloon with free admission for everyone, and I went there. Arvid was below deck and unfortunately missed it. It was the first-class passengers who performed, and it was very pleasant, even though I did not understand much of the English lyrics, but the music was beautiful to listen to.

A voluntary collection was taken up during the concert, though I do not remember for what purpose. The same morning we landed in New York, we had to undergo a medical examination on our arms to check if we were vaccinated against smallpox. Those who did not have clear scars had their arms scratched and were vaccinated on the spot. The approach to New York is very beautiful, much more beautiful than the city itself, which feels rather ugly and monotonous with its heavy rows of buildings and lack of parks and greenery. The grass is green here, but the trees have not budded yet. The climate is much like Sweden; the summers are warmer, but the winters are often colder. I have not seen any great floral display here in the eastern states yet; the only things I have noticed are willow, dandelions, and a few blossoming fruit trees. It seems that spring has progressed further back home in Sweden. The time difference is eight hours behind Swedish time.

At the entrance to New York, with Brooklyn on one side, New Jersey on the other, and New York itself with the emigrant station Castle Garden on the third, the enormous Statue of Liberty stands on its own small island. It is made of bronze with a granite base, and in her raised hand, she holds a symbol that from a distance looks like an apple (the torch). From a distance, we also saw the mighty Brooklyn Bridge. We docked at the Cunard Line's own pier, where all lines have their own large warehouses, and there we had to wait from eight o'clock in the morning until four in the afternoon while the luggage was unloaded and the customs inspection took place. The customs check went as smoothly as in England, and I do not think anyone had to pay duty. From there, we emigrants and our luggage were transported by a smaller boat to the Castle Garden park where passengers now disembark. There we were met by terrible crowding and confusion. We had to give our

name, age, and occupation before being let through. It was a massive chaos of different languages, shouting, and noise. It felt very overwhelming at first because you did not know where to go, and you were terrified of losing your things or your travel companions. One was also afraid of running into swindlers ("runners"), even though there was strict police guard outside the gates to keep unauthorized people away. Despite this, I saw several such swindlers who had managed to get inside or were loitering outside. At Castle Garden, it is virtually impossible to manage on your own unless you know the language or have companions who speak English. We actually managed better with the language in England than we do here in America, because the pronunciation is so different from the English we learned in Sweden. The difference in spoken language is much like that between Swedish and Danish, even though the written language is the same.

We stayed at a German hotel right near Castle Garden which cost 1 dollar per day including meals, which was very cheap. Three of us shared a room, and the hotel owner turned out to be born in Sweden. He was of great help to us, even though we were quite suspicious of him at first. The first thing we did after getting a hot meal at a properly set table was to take a bath, and it felt absolutely fantastic to feel like a clean human being again. From Castle Garden, I telegraphed Mrs. Uhlberg to let her know I had arrived, as I did not know if I could manage to find my way over to Brooklyn on my own. She came to the hotel the following morning, and we then took the elevated railway ("The elevated railway") to Central Park, which is said to be the absolute highlight of New York. There we looked at the menageries and walked along the paved paths.

There were many animals in the park, but also much that was missing. Unfortunately, we did not have time for more than that, as we had to arrange our train tickets from New York to California. With the help of our kind hotel owner, it went beyond all expectations; we got both cheaper and better tickets (\$50 each) than if we had booked them directly in Gothenburg. Furthermore, it allowed us to stop over in both New York and Chicago. We very much wanted to travel via Chicago to continue traveling with a former farmer of our own age from Vänersborg named Lönnerblad (whose father is a clergyman there and has applied for a position alongside Dean Helander in Falköping), and naturally to see the city of Chicago. While the other emigrants were forced to travel onward on the simple emigrant trains the same day they came to New York, we were able to stay for a full day and sleep a night in proper beds. We then traveled by a fast express train, which was just as cheap and went on the best line, so we actually arrived in Chicago ahead of the others.

We covered the distance to Chicago (said to be around 200 Swedish miles) in 30 hours, and the journey was very comfortable. There are no third-class carriages here, only first and second class, which are just as nice as first and second class in Sweden. The express train traveled at a dizzying speed, and we passed the Great Lakes and Niagara. We crossed an immense bridge over the Niagara River, but unfortunately, we did not see the falls themselves as they lay a bit further upstream. Upon arrival at Port Huron, which is the first town on the Canadian side, we underwent another customs check because Canada is British and does not belong to the USA. But since we were just traveling through on the express train, we did not have to pay duty. At Port Huron, the entire train was run onto a large train ferry bridge to be carried across the wide river, and on the other side, we had to change trains.

It then happened that the second-class carriages became full before we could get seats, so we had the great pleasure of riding in first class for the rest of the way to Chicago! But it was a rather chaotic situation when we had to change trains; we were told at the absolute last second, and by then we had unpacked most of our things in the compartment—slippers, blankets, bottles, and other small items were scattered about. It became a huge rush to get everything into the new train in a hurry. A tin water pitcher had to be left behind on the train. We must have looked quite funny stepping forward in the midday heat dressed in thick winter overcoats, with my large slippers sticking out of one pocket and a beer bottle out of the other, while carrying our arms full of

overnight bags, suitcases, blankets, umbrellas, brushes, books, and bundles of bread. To make it all even more tragi-comic, the bottom of my hatbox came loose, and I thought I would drop everything on the ground. But once we settled into first class, where we had access to fresh washing water and all amenities, we felt very satisfied. The train had only five carriages, but each carriage was three times as long as a normal Swedish train carriage, with a center aisle and red upholstered seats. The backrests can be flipped over so that you can sit facing each other if you are a group, or stretch out and sleep if there is plenty of room.

The American countryside looks very peculiar. Since the country previously consisted entirely of deep forests, the tree stumps remain everywhere—even right out in the fields. The stumps are usually completely black, which is because the forest was burned down to clear the land for cultivation. The train therefore travels through long areas consisting only of burned, half-broken trees and black stumps in wet marshlands. In the smaller country towns and out in the countryside, nothing remains of the neatness and orderliness one is used to in Sweden or England. Everything lies topsy-turvy; wagons, plows, junk, and waste lie dumped outside doors, stairs, and windows. People are not so particular about such things here. It looks the same at the railway stations. The countryside in the eastern states was rather ugly, but it became significantly more beautiful as we entered Canada and approached Chicago.

Here in Chicago, we have checked into a perfectly fine hotel for \$1.50 a day, and the meals for all three courses cost \$2. We think Chicago is a very pleasant city, much nicer than New York. Today we have had the opportunity to speak English, German, French, and Swedish on the streets. Now to another matter: since our train tickets from here to Los Angeles are valid for a whole year if we wish, we have been thinking about staying here in Chicago for a few days. We think it might be smart to try to find some work here at first. It is easier to learn the language here and get ahead because there are so incredibly many Swedes here, compared to if we went straight to California. If we go to California directly and things do not go well there, we might regret not giving Chicago a chance first, where we can stay for a longer time and then travel onward. Therefore, we will probably stay here for a few days to try for jobs, and if we find something, we might stay even longer. Should it not work out, we will move on immediately.

I will therefore pay a visit to Pastor Björk at 10 Whiting Street here in Chicago. If you write to me, you can address the letters there. If I am no longer here, he will take care of the letters and forward them to me. Perhaps you have already sent letters to Los Angeles? In that case, it is probably best that you wait to write more until you get the next letter from me so we know where I end up. Arvid does not have time to write himself, but he asks you to call Alm and Bärsta and say that we have made it this far on our journey, and I send the same regards. Give my best to the Helander family, the Sundbergs, and the Sahlins. Anyone who wants to is welcome to read this letter, but please ask them to overlook that it is a bit sloppily written due to the rush and the long text.

**Warmest greetings to you and my siblings from your affectionate son,
D.**